

The Endemic Recession: The Narrowing of American Crisis and the Expansion of American Precarity

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Introduction

The Trump Administration's One Big Beautiful Bill represented the largest upward transfer of wealth in the history of the United States. But its coverage largely obscured that fact, focusing instead on Republican unity in passing the legislation in spite of the losses that many rank-and-file Republican voters would face rather than the substantive impacts and world historic implications of the bill. This coverage mirrors many of the other economic victories that Trump has amassed for the top 1% during his second administration: the vicissitudes of realpolitik take precedence over the ways that those victories shape long-term outcomes for the working class. It can be easy to pin this on corporate media and its increasing desire to monetize views through the medium of feeding into partisan conflict particularly over the last 30 years [cite], but I think to do this under-emphasizes the ways that this type of centrality of the elite driven two-party conflict over the effects of the mass public finds flourish and analogue in the broader macro-economy itself.

How we talk about economic retrenchment, I argue, is downstream from the fact that changes in the American Political Economy have meant that what we don't consider crises paper over forms of risk-shifting (Hacker 2004) that are occurring at faster and faster rates. Recent work by Dara Strolovitch makes the claim that:

“the very notion of economic crisis relies on assumptions and practices that reflect, reproduce, and constitute prevailing attitudes and normative expectations about racialized and gendered labor and economic inequalities.” (Strolovitch 2023)

This astute point, I argue, is being exacerbated and expanded by the fact that as wealth concentrates in a more dramatic fashion, it ironically becomes routinized, expanding the bounds of what she calls a “non-crisis” (Strolovitch 2023).

This is playing out not just in terms of the expansion of something like debt and housing burden (though those are key players in this story) but in terms of how we understand and adjudicate broader macroeconomic health. While the United States is being driven further into unprecedented levels of financial precarity, it has somehow avoided the dreaded “R” word: recession. This is primarily attributed to both the cautious maneuvering of the Federal Reserve and the paper tiger of AI investment. Both of these factors, I argue, actually highlight the ways in which conceptions of macroeconomic health are increasingly divorced from the financial realities of most Americans. This is not to say that race and gender are not still powerful tools through which we can understand the depths of disparities that people are facing. Rather, the types of financial cushion offered by whiteness and masculinity are increasingly slipping as social forces, instead giving way to to an ever narrowing group of people unaffected by what Hacker calls “risk contagion” that is being spread to more people up and down the income distribution in disturbing and sometimes surprising combinations (Hacker 2004).

I argue that once we frontload substantive measures that focus on economic pain at the household and community level rather than macroeconomic resilience at the level of the multinational firm, we begin to see that the information something like a declaration of recession is supposed to give us is largely irrelevant to a large proportion of Americans. I theorize this casualization of crisis as “the endemic recession.”

Proceeding with Caution: Recessions and Wealth Concentration

What is the use value of knowing a country is in recession? Well, for one, it highlights where a country is within a basic business cycle.

Housing Burden Is More than Housing Burden

Works Cited

- Hacker, Jacob S. 2004. "Privatizing Risk Without Privatizing the Welfare State: The Hidden Politics of Social Policy Retrenchment in the United States." *The American Political Science Review* 98(2): 243–60. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/4145310>.
- Strolovitch, Dara. 2023. *When Bad Things Happen to Privileged People: Race, Gender, and What Makes a Crisis in America*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.